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Back in October, I wrote about Robert B. Parker and wondered if his estate would hire anyone to continue his "Spenser" series. Recently I read that Ace Atkins has been hired, and I have mixed feelings about this. On the one hand, I'm happy that I'll be able to read a new "Spenser" book sometime next year. On the other hand, I've been burned in the past by new authors continuing an old series.

Dozens of authors have written new "Sherlock Holmes" stories - some good, some bad. There are at least 11 authors who have unevenly produced dozens of new "official" books in L. Frank Baum's "Wizard Of Oz" series, and Robert B. Parker himself wrote two less than exceptional Philip Marlow books.

For me, though, no series has a worse history of continuations and false starts by new authors than the "James Bond" series.

And this is on my mind right now because, sitting on my desk is the new "James Bond" book by Jeffrey Deaver - "Carte Blanche."

For those of you who only know James Bond through the movies, Bond was created by Ian Fleming in 1953 and Fleming wrote 12 Bond novels and nine short stories before his death in 1964.

By 1964, however, Bond was no longer just a character in a dozen novels - he was a cultural phenomenon and Fleming's readers, movie fans, publisher and his estate didn't want the series to end. So, over the years several authors have published "James Bond" novels.

To begin with, the Fleming novels themselves are inconsistent. Some are great, some are not, and "The Spy Who Loved Me" is virtually unreadable. Despite their

variations, all of these books have what one critic describes as the "Fleming Sweep" - a characteristic of Fleming's writing that gives you a sense of place and scene that comes from Fleming's background as a journalist during World War II.

During the late '60s and throughout the '70s, new books were written by Kingsley Amis, John Pearson and Christopher Wood. Pearson's "Authorized Biography Of 007," from 1975, is probably the best of them and it's probably worth pointing out that the "Bond" movies of the mid-'70s weren't that good either. Bond was in a slump.

By the 1980s, though, things were looking up. John Gardner was commissioned by Fleming's estate to write new novels, and in 1981 the excellent "License Renewed" appeared. "For Special Services" and "Role Of Honor" were also good, but like Fleming, Gardner couldn't hit a home run every time.

Foul balls like "Icebreaker" and "Never Send Flowers" appeared among the 16 novels Gardner wrote.

After Gardner, Raymond Benson wrote a few unremarkable "Bond" books which were followed by a series of "young" James Bond books written by Charlie Higson.

An adult James Bond disappeared from the print world until 2008, when Sebastian Faulks, who is primarily known for historical fiction, was asked to write a "Bond" novel in commemoration of Fleming's 100th birthday. But it wasn't anything special.

Now in 2011, 58 years after the series began, here I am with "Carte Blanche" staring at me, daring me to read it, offering potential disappointment.

I'm encouraged that it's by Jeffrey Deaver, author of "The Burning Wire" and other detective thrillers, but I am fully aware that this is no guarantee of success.

Of course, if you're interested in reading any of these books, the Latah County Library District has all of the "Bond" books by Fleming and several of the others - all of which can be found in the library catalog at www.valnet.org. We have many of the movies too.

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